

EYEWITNESS May–July 1864

Andersonville Prison Camp

In February 1864, Andersonville—also known as Camp Sumter—in Georgia, received its first Union prisoners. Throughout the remaining months of the war, over 45,000 Union soldiers would languish in this overcrowded prison. A lack of shelter, food, medicine, and sanitation led not only to rampant disease, but also to the death of approximately 13,000 Union prisoners of war.

Friday, May 27, 1864

“Inside the camp death stalked on every hand ... one third of the original enclosure was swampy—a mud of liquid filth, voidings from the thousands, seething with maggots in full activity. This daily increased by the necessities of the inmates, the only place being accessible for the purpose. Through this mass pollution, passed the only water that found its way through the Bull Pen ... I have known 3,000 men to wait in line to get water, and the line was added to as fast as reduced, from daylight to dark, yes, even into the night ... the heat of the sun, blistering him, or the drenching rains soaking him, not a breath of fresh air, and we had no covering but Heaven’s canopy. Air-loaded with unbearable, fever-laden stench from the poison sink of putrid mud and water, continually in motion by the activity of the germs of death. We could not get away from it—we ate it, drank it and slept in it. What a wonder that men died, or were so miserable as to prefer instant death to that which they had seen hourly taking place.”

Tuesday, July 19, 1864

“The cases of insanity were numerous. Men, strong in mentality, heart and hope were in a few short months, yes, often in a few weeks, reduced to imbeciles and maniacs. Today they know you and look upon you as friends and comrades; tomorrow they are peevish, whining, childish creatures, or raving maniacs. Some would beg for something to eat; others asked for wife, mother, children, or other relatives ... the mental anguish of those days and months was the slowest torture to him who still had a clear brain.”